magnanimity of men,' Akbar said, now scornful of the men, 'that they should seek their deliverance through the self sacrifice of their wives.'

To ensure that women were not forced to commit sati against their will Akbar appointed officials in every town so that only 'those who of their own impulse wished to commit sati might be allowed to do so'. Akbar had already decreed that 'Hindu child-widows who had not enjoyed conjugal relations should not be burnt; but if the Hindus should find this difficult, they were not to be interfered with.' It was a fine balance that Akbar tried to maintain, between his own growing empathy for the plight of the women, and his awareness of the prickly honour of his Hindu subjects, some of whom were deeply attached to the practice of sati.

Akbar's sensitivity to the distressing vulnerability of women resulted in a number of orders and measures being passed during these years to try and protect them. He had always abhorred the marriage of children and said about it that 'it is particularly distressing under a law where a woman (being so much younger than her husband) cannot marry again'. Child marriages were rampant at this time, having been noticed by Ralph Fitch who said that 'we found marriages great store, both in towns and villages in many places where we passed, of boys of eight or ten years and girls of five or six years old…. They do not lie together until they be ten years old.' Akbar raised the minimum age for marriage to sixteen years for boys and fourteen for girls, and instructed the kotwals to establish the ages of the bride and groom before allowing weddings to take place. Unfortunately, writes Badauni, 'this greatly filled the pockets of officials such as Kotwal's men', as people began bribing the officials to allow the practice to continue.

Akbar also brought in an order in 1587 permitting widows to remarry, 'in the manner that the people of India do not prohibit'. He was greatly saddened by the notion that 'here in India among the modest, a woman once married cannot go [again] to anyone else'. That Akbar would find the idea of widows not being allowed to re-marry puzzling and distressing is understandable given the Timurids' pragmatic approach to women's chastity. Women who 'fell' to enemies in times of war were never blamed for their predicament, and were taken back with honour by their families when they were returned. In Akbar's own family there would have been the glowing example of Khanzada Begum, twice forcibly married to Uzbek men who were sworn enemies of Babur, and then received with gratitude and love at the court of Babur, who gave her the highest title of honour of